

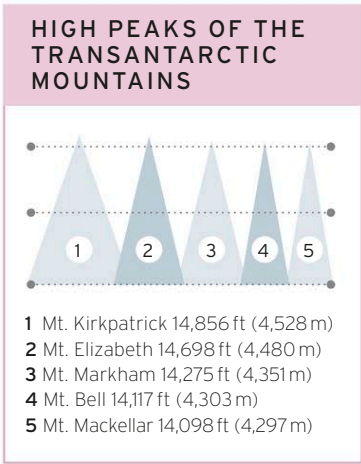


The Transantarctic Mountains

Antarctica’s longest mountain range, which was first sighted by people only in 1841

The Transantarctic Mountains are a curved belt of mountains, about 2,200 miles (3,500 km) long, that cross Antarctica. One section divides the continent into its two main parts: East and West Antarctica. Much of the rest of the belt runs along a part of the coast of East Antarctica, including a long stretch where it borders the Ross Ice Shelf. Some large glaciers flow through gaps in the range in this area.

The mountain belt has many subranges, including the Queen Maud Mountains and the Royal Society Range. Eight out of its 10 highest peaks are in just one subrange, the Queen Alexandra Range. Parts of the Transantarctic Mountains were first sighted by the British naval explorer Captain James Ross in 1841, but the Queen Alexandra Range was not discovered until 1908 (by a British Antarctic expedition). Life in the range’s interior is limited to microorganisms—such as bacteria and algae. However, in the ancient past a wide variety of animals and plants thrived there, as evidenced by fossils of primitive amphibians and reptiles in rocks laid down 400–180 million years ago.



▽ **BREAKING THROUGH THE ICE**
Among the few features not buried under ice, the tops of the mountains consist of sedimentary rock layers lying on top of granites and gneisses.



△ **WHITE DOME**
This view of Mount Erebus, which is spouting steam at its summit, is from the ice-covered Ross Sea. Erebus has a moderately steep, irregular dome shape.